Snowden considered this the ultimate invasion of privacy. Speaking to a reporter about MonsterMind, Snowden commented, "That means violating the Fourth Amendment, seizing private communications without a warrant, without probable cause or even a suspicion of wrongdoing. For everyone, all the time."[7]

Then, on March 13, 2013, Snowden read a news account of a statement given the previous day by James Clapper, director of National Intelligence, to a US Senate committee. When asked by a senator whether the NSA collected any type of data on Americans, Clapper responded, "No, sir."[8] Floored by what he considered an outright lie, Snowden made his decision to become a whistle-blower.

Yet he had doubts. "It's really hard to take that step," he said in an interview. "Not only do I believe in something, I believe in it enough that I'm willing to set my own life on fire and burn it to the ground."[9] Though he believed revealing what he saw as government wrongdoing was ethical, he knew the US government would not see it that way. He was especially worried about his family, friends, and girlfriend; he feared government authorities would come after anyone who had known him. The thought kept him awake at night.

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